



4



5

A NEW WAY TO UNWIND

4. The 14th edition of SulaFest, a wine and music festival, made a splash this February at Sula Vineyards in Nasik

5. For those who would like to enjoy a weekend at Sula, it offers two resorts—The Source and Beyond—with rooms priced in the ₹10,000-12,000 range

Grande Tour & Tasting (₹1,000 per person), which includes a more in-depth wine gallery tour along with wine tasting paired with a sumptuous cheese platter. While wineries in Nashik welcome visitors all around the year, the ideal time to visit is from January to March during the grape harvest season, when you can also partake in grape picking. Additionally, the winter months from October to March are perfect for vineyard explorations and those Instagrammable shots.

“For those looking for a deeper dive, Chandon also offers exclusive masterclasses led by myself, where visitors can learn the nuances of winemaking and food pairings,” says Kaushal Khairnar, Winemaker, Chandon India. Khairnar adds that besides the tours which are popular across different age groups, guests also come to enjoy the sunset with a glass of Chandon sparkling wine.

Near Nashik, on the banks of the Nira River, lies the town of Akluj, home to the Fratelli Vineyards spread over 240 acres. Guests can enjoy a day trip for ₹1,500 which includes a visit to the winery along with a tasting. Or you could stay for the weekend in their guest house for anywhere between ₹7,000-14,000 for two days for a couple. You could also hire the entire guest house for eight people for three days for ₹44,999 (₹85,999 for a long weekend). Enjoy riding a bicycle through the vineyards, through fields of Chenin and Gewürztraminer (both are varieties of grapes) as the sun sets, engulfing you in a heady ambience.

Most vineyards do not allow walk-ins, so it is best to book an online tour. Go for a wine tour in India to realise how much we have accepted wine as part of our palate, some even pairing it with *bhaji* (onion fritters). **BT**

@smitabw